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Analysis of
SHU HARI
in KARATE-DO

*When a Fighting Art
Becomes a Fine Art*

Hermann Bayer, Ph.D.

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Contents

<i>Foreword by Hanshi William R. Hayes</i>	ix
<i>Foreword by Professor Dr. Wolfgang Herbert</i>	x
<i>Foreword by Kyoshi Dr. James Hatch</i>	xv
<i>Foreword by Kyoshi Thomas E. Ward</i>	xvii
<i>Foreword by Kyoshi Bruno Ballardini</i>	xix
<i>Introduction: New Significance of Shu Ha Ri in Postwar Karatedo— or a Mistaken Paradigm?</i>	xxiii

Chapter 1: A Centuries-Old Japanese Fine Arts Principle Finds Its Way into Modern Karate	1
Protecting Others and Oneself from Physical and Nonphysical Harm Is the Universal Principle of Okinawan Karate-jutsu That Differs from the Self- Perfection Principle in Japanese Karatedo	5
The Japanese Shu Ha Ri Developmental Principle and Its Martial Arts Ramifications	10
Though the Shu Ha Ri Concept Is Widespread in Today's Japanese Karatedo, It Is Unknown to Many Karateka	18
Shu Ha Ri in the Martial Arts versus in the Fine Arts	22
Different Shu Ha Ri Interpretations Are Used in Karate Today	24
How Individualism in Western Culture May Impact the Way Shu Ha Ri Is Understood	25
The Yardsticks That Measure the Adequacy of Interpretations of Karate Moves	29
The Yardstick in Karate-Jutsu Is Measurable Self-Defense Impact	31
Subjective Interpretations of Forms in Karatedo Are Not Factually Measurable	33
Forms as Defined by Associations Are the Yardstick in Sports-Karate	34
Shu Ha Ri, Meditation, Religion, and the Esoteric	35
Differing Shu Ha Ri Characteristics Are Found in Today's Karate-jutsu, Karatedo, and Sports-Karate	43

Chapter 2: Shu Ha Ri Is a Japanese Socio-Cultural Concept, Not an Okinawan One	45
Okinawa Shows Subcultural Peculiarities That Appeared Inferior to Prewar Japan	45
Shu Ha Ri Is Not a Traditional Principle of Okinawan Karate-jutsu	48
Initially, There Were No Styles in Classic Okinawan Karate-jutsu	52
Okinawans Did Usually Not “Break Away” from Their Sensei	56
Okinawan Masters May Not Officially See Shu Ha Ri as a Relevant Principle but They Developed Students Beyond Their Own Teachings	59
Cultural Norms and Social Mechanisms in Japan Support Conformity and Not Breaking Away from Traditions	61
Senpai/Kohai, the Social Mechanism That Maintains Traditions	62
Giri, the Norm of Conformity and Mutual Obligations	64
The Initial Shu Ha Ri Understanding in the Japanese Fine Arts (Including the Ikebana Parable “How Jiro Became a Sensei” by Thomas E. Ward)	65
Chapter 3: Based on Claims of Cultural Superiority, Japan Converts Okinawan Karate-jutsu into Karatedo and Inserts Japanese Philosophies	71
Prewar Japan’s Self-Proclaimed Cultural and Racial Superiority	72
Based on Self-Acclaimed Cultural Supremacy, Japan Redefines Karate Since Its Okinawan Version Embodied “Backwardness” in the Eyes of the Japanese	74
Japan’s Redefinition of Karate as Karatedo, a Path toward Self-Perfection, and Its Adoption as a National Cultural Symbol	76
Some Major Changes to the Okinawan Conception of Universal Self-Protection in Japanese Karatedo	79
Formalizing Karatedo into a Japanese Fine Art Allows Shu Ha Ri to Be Incorporated into It and Gives Rise to the Development of Styles	85
Chapter 4: The Application of a Truncated Shu Ha Ri Concept in Modern Management	91
Business Consultants Discover Shu Ha Ri	93
Misunderstandings of Shu Ha Ri in Business Applications	94
Chapter 5: Misinterpretations of Shu Ha Ri May Allow Excuses for Laxity	97
Karatedo’s Commercialization May Encourage Interpretations of Shu Ha Ri as Breaking Away	98
Individualism May Turn into Self-Absorption and Narcissism if Shu Ha Ri Is Interpreted as Breaking Away	100

Transcending in the Ri-Phase and Some Possible Misinterpretations (with contributions by Thomas E. Ward)	103
Shu Ha Ri May Be Used to Sell Fantasy Moves as Genuine Techniques	103
Shu Ha Ri May Be Used to Reinvent the Wheel	104
“New” Karate Styles May Not Be New at All but Rediscovered Traditional Techniques	105
How to Find Instructors in the Kind of Karate One Wants to Learn	107
Chapter 6: Parallels and Differences Between Shu Ha Ri and Western Educational Concepts and Their Probable Mutual Supplementation (with Contributions by Thomas E. Ward)	109
Modern Western Educational Concepts	110
Limitations and Advantages of Western Concepts Compared to Shu Ha Ri	113
Chapter 7: The Essence of Shu Ha Ri Is Its Coexisting “Trinity of Phases”	119
Trinity of Coexisting Phases in Shu Ha Ri Instead of Skill Levels	119
Holistic Thinking Overcomes Assumed Contradictions	122
<i>Excuse: Real Fights in Contrast to Consensual Plays</i>	128
Chapter 8: Conclusion and Consequences	131
Physical, Mental, and Spiritual Development Covers the Totality of Karate Today	137
Integrating a Well-Established Western Educational Concept with Established Asian Teaching Methods May Help Retain Students in Traditional Karate (with contributions by Thomas E. Ward)	140
Classic Karate-jutsu and Old-Style Karatedo Dojos Are Losing Students at an Alarming Rate	141
Instruction Alone Is Not Sufficient for Advanced Learning	144
In a Traditional Western Dojo, Western Educational Concepts Can Support Established Asian Teaching Routines	147
The Necessity of a Yardstick to Formulate Meaningful Learning Objectives	150
The Symbiosis of Eastern and Western Teaching Concepts	152
<i>Excuse: Japan’s Cultural Roots of Confucianism and Taoism</i>	153
<i>List of Abbreviations</i>	156
<i>List of Photos and Graphs</i>	157
<i>Explanations of East Asian Terms in Dr. Hermann Bayer’s Books</i>	159
<i>References</i>	169
<i>Index</i>	177
<i>About the Author</i>	181

FOREWORD BY

HANSHI WILLIAM R. HAYES

Dr. Bayer's newest book about *Shu Ha Ri*—which means to “follow, transcend, break away”—was both a pleasure to read and to learn from. A skilled researcher and thought leader when it comes to topics such as *Shu Ha Ri*, Hermann also happens to be an active and serious martial artist who has taken this somewhat obscure socio-cultural construct of *Shu Ha Ri* and properly, historically, and practically contextualized it using his well-honed research skills throughout the process. For this we should all be immensely grateful as little clear and useful information has been previously published—or otherwise succinctly transmitted—on the topic.

This book will undoubtedly be of great assistance to students and teachers alike who might muse, “In what ways can I achieve further understanding of the art I have been gifted with?”

Written with unconditional passion and intellectual depth, *Analysis of Shu Ha Ri in Karate-do: When a Fighting Art Becomes a Fine Art* presents the reader with a masterful explication of a too-often misunderstood, culturally misplaced concept vital to the preservation, understanding, growth, and usefulness of Okinawa's unique life-protection art.

Enjoy this book with gratitude just as you might also enjoy your next sunrise.

William R. Hayes

“Old Student”

Hanshi 10th Dan *Shobayashi Ryu*

Major US-Marine Corps (retired)

FOREWORD BY

PROFESSOR DR. WOLFGANG HERBERT

Shu Ha Ri, Bushidô, and Zen-Buddhism as Invented Traditions in Japanese Karatedo

Hermann Bayer is a distinguished scholar-practitioner and a staunch and convincing advocate for recognizing karate as a cultural heritage of Okinawan “karate as a complex and rich art that needs to be preserved in its classic form,” as he himself declares. With his two books *Analysis of Genuine Karate: Misconceptions, Origins, Development, and True Purpose* and *Analysis of Genuine Karate 2: Sociocultural Development, Commercialization, and Loss of Essential Knowledge*—which I recommend perusing as a propaedeutic reading—he has already become a distinct voice in the field of karate studies. I deem it an honor to contribute some introductory remarks and additional comments on his new publication about *Shu Ha Ri* in Karatedo, which will be the most comprehensive work on the topic.

To ask the right—and often a simple—question can open the door to exploration and widen perspectives. Now, here is the query: *why is Shu Ha Ri relatively unknown among karate practitioners and when did it start to pop up in writing(s) about karate?* The expedition can begin.

The concept as such is said to go back to a stanza in the scroll “Rikyû dôka” (利休道歌), which describes the way of the tea as celebrated by the master Sen no Rikyû (1522–1591): 規矩作法 守り尽くして破るとも離るるとても本を忘るな (*kuki sahô mamoritsukushite yaburu to mo hanaruru to te mo moto o wasuru na!*) “Do not forget the origin, even when you, after meticulously preserving (*shu* 守) the guidelines and etiquette, break away (*ha* 破) and even liberate (*ri* 離) yourself from those.”

It is said that the principle of *Shu Ha Ri* was constructed from this line by combination of the three respective characters in Sino-Japanese. In the original they turn up in their verbal form and Japanese reading. Two points are pertinent here: firstly, this concept of three “stages” of learning and finally mastering an art or a craft originates in the *fine arts* and found its way into other creative activities like music, dance, theatre, poetry, calligraphy and the like. Secondly, Rikyû admonishes us

not to forget or neglect the “origin” or basis (*moto* 本, also read: *hon*; it is the *hon* in *kihon* 基本 = basics, fundamentals), thus indicating that as far and yonder as one might go, the foundation remains present and supports one’s endeavor. As a well-known Japanese saying goes: 初心忘るべからず (*shoshin wasurubekarazu*) “do not forget the spirit [you had] as a novice,” an attitude that Zen-masters like to call the beginner’s mind. You always return to the basics and learn afresh. The *Shu Ha Ri* model turns out to be—rather than linear—a *spiral*, as you will be shown in detail in the book at hand.

“Invented tradition” has become a well-known notion and is neatly valid also in the case of *Shu Ha Ri* in the martial arts. I would even like to speak of an “imposed tradition” in cases where a tradition of a dominant cultural strand is grafted upon another marginal one. In the matter at hand it concerns mainland Japanese cultural elements that were transplanted into an originally Okinawan set of skills for self-protection. Only after the transformation of Okinawan karate into a Japanese “martial way,” namely *budô*, and its conversion into a fine art for self-perfection, spiritual growth, and character building, the importation of the idea of *Shu Ha Ri* into karate-dô became congruent with this new form of karate as an art of self-cultivation. Hence, the time lag and relative lack of familiarity with the term by many karateka. *Shu Ha Ri*, as Hermann Bayer rightly contends, entered the vocabulary of karate noticeably after WWII. The same phenomenon can be observed in two other cases of imposed traditions: the warrior code of *bushidô* and a rather distorted brand of Zen-Buddhism.

While one of the most influential organizations, the JKA (Japan Karate Association) informs us on their homepage (under “philosophy”) that karate is based on Zen and *bushido*, the latter of which *is an invented tradition par excellence* and was originally relevant merely for a marginal part of the population (5 to 7 percent), the class or caste of the *bushi*, the warriors, common Samurai. After the Meiji Restoration and abolishment of the feudal class system, *bushido* was propagated as the core value system of Japan, embodying its “unique soul” (*Yamato damashii*) and to be embraced by every Japanese citizen. Sociologists call this the “samuraization” of Japanese society in order to forge a national identity, conformity, and solidarity, and consequently it was utilized for the all-out mobilization for the wars Japan was going to fight. Loyalty to the Emperor (formerly to the feudal lord), willingness to die for him on the battlefield, absolute obedience, endurance of

hardships, frugality, fulfillment of one's duties and obligations were elements of this "imperial" *bushido*, as it was dubbed by the foremost Western authority on the topic, Oleg Benesch. The martial arts and karate were lastingly influenced by this zeitgeist and instrumentalized by the then-extant government and army. Karate came to Japan at a time when the *bushi* have vanished, and *bushido* never had any leverage in Okinawa, thus the two have historically nothing to do with each other. The Samurai did not know anything about karate; their bare-handed method of self-defense was *yawara*, which later evolved into jujutsu and judo. *Bushido and karate are unrelated and an anachronistic mismatch*. The same could be said at least about Okinawan karate and *Shu Ha Ri*. *Bushido* is obsolete, historically contaminated, a fictitious construct that has been imposed onto karate to make it more "Japanese." In my eyes, *bushido* in karate is superfluous and should be kept apart from it.

Since the conscientious studies by Brian Victoria and Christopher Ives we also know how far the Buddhist establishment and notably *Zen-Buddhist clergy have been involved into the ideological mobilization* of soldiers and the populace during wartimes. The Buddhist ontological or metaphysical teaching of the non-existence of a permanent self or "soul" has been perverted into two twisted forms. "No self" was on the one hand interpreted as "self-less" service for country and *tenno*, thus as an act of loyalty in a Confucian ethical prescriptive and moral sense. On the other hand "no self" or "no mind" (*mushin*) in the martial arts was deemed to describe a mental state of total aloofness, alertness, unperturbed by intellectual interference or emotions like anger, angst, or paralysis. Hence the ideal state of mind to fight and strike an enemy and to kill him with no ego, no guilt, and not a trace of empathy. Zen Buddhism was therefore cut off from its ethical and soteriological foundations and instrumentalized as a psychotechnical tool to become a superior swordsman or soldier. The Buddhist values of compassion and not to harm any sentient being were conveniently disposed of. This "warrior Zen" is a pragmatic and reductionist version which was propagated by D. T. Suzuki and brought into connection with *bushido* by him. He was and probably is the most read author on Zen in martial arts circles. Again, Zen was of not much consequence in Okinawan karate; it was imposed on *hondo* karate in order to align it with the old budo-tradition, in particular swordsmanship, and to sanctify it with a Japanese religio-philosophical tradition.

As Dr. Bayer notes in the first of the above-mentioned books of his, the incorporation of Zen into karate happened in a specific time of social change starting in the late 1960s. Some keywords as reminders: student rebellion, anti-Vietnam-war movement, human rights organizations (anti-racism, feminism, gay/lesbian rights), environmental protection, Woodstock, hippies, Indian gurus, humanistic/transpersonal psychology, psychedelics, New-Age spirituality and much more. Bayer: “New values, evolving from aspirations for peace, from experimenting with self-insight and self-development, from meditation and adoption of Eastern philosophies and their approaches like Zen-meditation, yoga, and tai chi, add an additional layer to the explanation of the broad attraction that the spiritual, health-oriented version of karatedo quickly gained amongst young generations of new disciples in search of a new meaning of life and of the ‘way.’” In this context, Zen became topical in karate circles. Since according to D. T. Suzuki’s hyperbolic view every aspect of Japanese culture, especially every fine art, was said to be influenced by Zen-Buddhism, it could be that *Shu Ha Ri* was “detected” and transplanted into karate against this backdrop. One of its “Western” interpretations might have been influenced by the search for “self-actualization” (Maslow’s term adopted by Dr. Bayer), namely the breaking away from teacher and tradition in order to create something “new.”

The scope of Bayer’s work is extensive, and he also hints at pathological outcomes of the exegesis of *Shu Ha Ri* when laid claim to by narcissistic personalities or commercially oriented martial arts entrepreneurs. He mentions truncated versions of *Shu Ha Ri* in name only for coaching or the refurbishment of management principles. Funnily, it is in this frame of reference that it readily pops up, if one googles *Shu Ha Ri*. Some use it to fill a market niche or as an exotic and unique selling point for their brand of leadership training.

Dr. Bayer also contrasts *Shu Ha Ri* with Western models of teaching and skill acquirement and looks for a coherent educational approach, where the Asian method of mimicking and modeling, a one-way-only and top-down mode, is complemented with actively involving and stimulating students via assignment of tasks like analysis and reflection upon techniques and their meaning and experimentation on applications. This is followed with deliberations on combining traditional Japanese/Confucian educational concepts with Western methodologies, namely stating clear educational objectives, methods of instruction,

and assessment of outcomes. This takes the different (learning) personalities of the students into account and avoids a “one size fits all” and autocratic instructor-centered teaching approach, which dominates “traditional” Asian tutoring.

Hermann Bayer’s book gives plenty of food for thought, for safeguarding wholesome traditions (*Shu*), innovation and personal modifications (*Ha*), and transcending monocultural contexts (*Ri*) by combining Eastern and Western approaches. This book on *Shu Ha Ri* is in a way an exercise and execution of this principle and an exhaustive study on the theme. It is written by an analytical and scientific mind and is a contribution to understanding how certain notions we are prone to take as a given actually evolved historically and in a particular setting. Such a genealogical investigation also reveals peculiar interpretations that unfold over time and geographical space. Imposed or likewise invented traditions are not spurious per se. To expose them as what they are—as was done here with *Shu Ha Ri*—enables us to reassess them and to decide if we want to accept, adjust, or discard them. All cultures and traditions are hybrid and living entities.

“Habent sua fata libelli” (books have their destiny) goes a saying in Latin, and in this sense I wish for this book to have the fate to become a classic regarding the topic *Shu Ha Ri*.

Dr. Wolfgang Herbert

Professor for Comparative Cultural Studies at Tokushima University, Japan

6th Dan *Shôtôkan Karate-dô*

FOREWORD BY

KYOSHI DR. JAMES HATCH

Shu Ha Ri in Karate-dō: A Bridge Between East and West

Hermann Bayer's *Shu Ha Ri in Karate-dō: When a Fighting Art Becomes a Fine Art* makes a unique and significant contribution to the discourse on the philosophical underpinnings of Okinawan karate. The book is a meticulous exploration of the concept of *Shu Ha Ri*—a cornerstone of Japanese cultural and artistic pedagogy—as it has been applied, adapted, and sometimes misconstrued within the context of martial arts, specifically karate.

Bayer's work is commendable in its ambition to bridge the chasm between the East and West. He deftly navigates the intricacies of translating a deeply rooted Japanese concept into a framework understandable to a Western audience, a task that is particularly challenging given the stark contrasts between Japan's collectivist ethos and the West's individualistic tendencies. The author's success lies in his ability to identify and articulate the core principles of *Shu Ha Ri* while simultaneously acknowledging the cultural nuances that shape its interpretation.

A key strength of Bayer's work is his meticulous tracing of the concept's philosophical roots. By anchoring *Shu Ha Ri* within the broader context of Confucian and Buddhist thought, he provides a rich historical and intellectual foundation for understanding its significance. This approach is essential for appreciating the concept's depth and complexity, as it reveals how it has evolved and adapted over centuries.

Moreover, Bayer's exploration of the concept's application in various artistic disciplines offers valuable insights into its versatility. By demonstrating how *Shu Ha Ri* has been utilized in fields outside of martial arts, the author underscores its potential as a universal framework for learning and mastery. This comparative approach enriches the reader's understanding of the concept and its applicability to diverse human endeavors.

However, Bayer does more than merely provide a descriptive analysis of *Shu Ha Ri*. He also engages critically with the concept, particularly in its application to karate. His astute examination of how the

transition from Okinawan karate to Japanese karate-dō has influenced the interpretation and practice of *Shu Ha Ri*, and his highlighting of the potential pitfalls of imposing a Japanese cultural construct onto a different martial tradition, demonstrate the depth of his analysis.

By juxtaposing the collectivist underpinnings of *Shu Ha Ri* with the individualistic ethos of the West, Bayer invites readers to consider the implications of this cultural divide for karate practice. This comparative perspective is essential for understanding the challenges and opportunities of reconciling traditional values with contemporary realities.

In conclusion, *Analysis of Shu Ha Ri in Karate-dō* is a scholarly and insightful exploration of a complex concept. Bayer's meticulous research and ability to bridge Eastern and Western thought make this book a valuable contribution to martial arts studies. By offering a comprehensive framework for understanding *Shu Ha Ri*, the author has laid the groundwork for future research and discussions on the evolution and purpose of karate.

James M. Hatch, EdD

7th Dan *Chito Ryu*, *Sichibu Jyuku*

Oyamada-machi, Japan

FOREWORD BY

KYOSHI THOMAS E. WARD

Educational Principles Help Instructors to Organize and Systematize Their Teachings

My whole life I've been a karateka and an educator. I've studied *Shorin-Ryu* karate since the age of thirteen, and haven't stopped learning in over fifty years. I taught English and remedial reading in public schools, and, eventually, I pursued a full-time career as a karate instructor and ran my own school for twenty-five-plus years. I never forgot that my main value was the purity of the art and the quality of the teaching that I could provide. I visited numerous other dojos to study, to instruct, or simply as a guest, constantly taking note of the teaching methods and student quality in these schools, and I tried to emulate some of the finer qualities I saw in teachers, and to ensure that the lesser qualities were eliminated from my own school. Many, many hours I spent on evaluation panels for various testing in various schools, where I saw many things I admired, and some things with which I was ashamed to be associated.

Permanently on the lookout for opportunities to improve my own karate teachings, I became aware of the concept of *Shu Ha Ri*, which can be understood as a Japanese andragogical idea, as a way to educate adults. I comprehended it on a basic level, but initially did not give it much thought. Later, in college, I learned about modern educational concepts, like Bloom's taxonomy, and I linked this Western concept to the Japanese one, because as teachers we are always curious about how much our students comprehend at a surface level and how much they actually can apply to their lives outside the dojo doors. Both Bloom's taxonomy and the concept of *Shu Ha Ri* seemed to me helpful methods of measuring a student's understanding in this sense, and the text before you will shed more light on such a thought.

However, what this book delivers to the body of knowledge in our art goes way beyond that. It clarifies why and how *Shu Ha Ri* is a genuine Japanese concept and not an Okinawan one at the birthplace of karate. This distinction seems quite important as conservative Okinawan karate circles adamantly insist on keeping their Okinawan approach separated, unique, and not to be mixed up with Japanese ways. It clarifies further,

how *Shu Ha Ri*, as an initial Japanese fine arts principle and not a martial arts principle, was later applied into Japanese martial arts in general, and into karatedo in particular, during a process that converted Okinawa's self-protection art into something closer to a Japanese fine art of self-perfection; that is, into the form that represents today's mainstream karatedo practice. Misconceptions and differing interpretations by various groups with their own agenda during such a process seem unavoidable and created a rather convoluted picture of this *Shu Ha Ri* concept, one not well-known to all karateka in the first place. Fortunately, Dr. Bayer weaves historic, socio-cultural, political, philosophical, psychological, and commercial components into a complex analysis that finally gives a clear picture and that addresses those doubts and questions about ascent or alibi which inevitably arise when an Okinawan self-defense art is changed into a Japanese fine art.

An additional highlight is the inclusion of educational principles and approaches that help instructors to organize and to systematize their teaching approach and to enhance traditional instructor-centered concepts by using approaches that were developed to better reach Western minds.

I met Dr. Bayer several years ago at a *Shorin-Ryu* camp, where I taught educational psychology to my fellow martial arts instructors—what I decided to do after having taught other subjects at various martial arts camps and seminars for a few decades. Later, I discovered that he was a highly accomplished black belt in another karate system, who had started over in *Shorin-ryu* and had worked his way up to black belt ranks there as well. His willingness to do this speaks volumes about his humility and his desire to permanently learn and grow; and his well-rounded academic and professional background qualify him for an analysis that goes well beyond popular, constricted narratives. It seems to me that he understands the martial arts on a deeper level than most, the differing Okinawan and Japanese views of karate in general, as well as *Shu Ha Ri* interpretations in particular, when a fighting art is converted into a fine art. We communicated about several aspects of this socio-cultural phenomenon, which eventually led to me contributing some thoughts to this book.

I am convinced that all readers, martial artists or not, will greatly enjoy Dr. Bayer's analysis, that it will give everyone plenty of food for thought, and, if you're an instructor, that it will allow you to see promising perspectives.

Thomas E. Ward

Kyoshi 7th Dan *Shorin Ryu Shorinkan*

FOREWORD BY

KYOSHI BRUNO BALLARDINI

“Crystalized” Japanese Karate-Do Is the Result of Adopting a Western “Taxonomy”

Hermann Bayer offers us a profound and most valuable reflection on a topic that is as crucial to karate studies as it has hitherto been ignored, namely, how modern Japanese karate appropriated Okinawan karate in the early 1900s by not only simplifying its techniques but also by codifying principles that had previously remained unexpressed. These provisions are to be seen and understood in a broader context of socio-cultural and historic circumstances.

There was a disruptive phase in Japan’s cultural history between the end of the Meiji Period (1868–1912) and the early years of the Shōwa period (1926–1989) that coincides with a rush to modernize everything, and with the irresistible attraction of Western ideas in Japan. During this period, Japan not only avidly absorbed Western techniques, technology, and customs, but also Western logic and a new way of organizing knowledge through *taxonomy* (from Greek: τάξις, *tàxis*, i.e., “order” and νόμος, *nòmos*, that is “standard” or “rule”). This approach defines a set of rules for the nomenclature and classification of objects, where “classification” means the application of a taxonomic scheme suitable for naming, defining, and categorizing objects of observation and of organizing them into groups and subgroups.

Modern taxonomy was invented by Carl von Linné, born in Sweden in 1707, who published in 1735 the first edition of *Systema Naturae*, in which he outlined such a new system of classification for the sciences. The first contact with his method in Japan occurred when Carl Peter Thunberg, Linné’s disciple, stayed there for a year as a doctor for the Dutch Trading House and later published *Flora Japonica*. Thereafter, from the Meiji Period onward, as Emperor Akihito’s comprehensive publication on the use of taxonomy in Japan describes, the modernization drive resulted in a widespread adoption of this Western method to rationalize knowledge; it penetrated many fields, including the martial arts. Paradoxically, the first person to apply this method to karate was

not Japanese, but the Okinawan master Gichin Funakoshi, who was determined to export the local art to mainland Japan.

It should be noted that the peculiar characteristics of ancient Okinawan karate, which came intact and unaltered until the early 1900s, was that most of its techniques had either no name or were sometimes labeled by the phonetization of a Chinese word. But even if the techniques taught would have had names, it is very unlikely that the masters of ancient karate would ever tell those to their students, deeming it useless, since practice was based on imitation and took place in absolute silence. Funakoshi rationalized the corpus of ancient karate by producing the first taxonomy and nomenclature of karate in a way that appealed to Japan's modern classification trend. He named techniques that had never been named, and he replaced Chinese terms with Japanese terms, although his early classifications of kata created some confusion as Mario McKenna pointed out in 2003, in the first issue of *Classic Fighting Arts* magazine.

Why was it that the Japanese greatly appreciated the application of taxonomy and nomenclature to karate as initiated by Funakoshi? It was because of the attractiveness of Western thought systems in general that were adopted in Japan at that time. In terms of the taxonomy thought system, specifically for Westerners, naming an object was equivalent to knowing it, and thus, in a sense, "owning" it. Within such lines of thought, to appropriate ancient Okinawan karate, Japanese martial arts officials proceeded in the direction pointed out by Funakoshi. They categorized every move and technique, and they applied the same approach to basic principles such as *Shu Ha Ri* as well. In fact, before these principles were codified in Japan, they were rather an implicit consequence of internalizing a practice; they represented a kind of awareness of what the practitioners were expected to acquire along their path of learning. That way, principles were part of the path one proceeds along but does not even need to talk about. Consequently, there is no trace of this concept in the Okinawan masters' writings that have come down to us.

In summation, modern Japanese karate, including its principle of *Shu Ha Ri*, is the result of a new system of organizing knowledge, it is the result of adopting a Western concept of categorizing elements within a subject that was implemented on mainland Japan. Kenji Tokitsu, a sociologist and karate master, was the first researcher to define the consequence of this procedure as "crystallization."

Crystallizing a living art such as early karate amounted to “congealing” its figures and principles in the same way that nineteenth-century Linnean scholars fixed butterflies with a pin inside the frame of a taxonomy, giving the outside observer the illusion of possessing the knowledge of the objects these frames contain, including how they evolved. In doing so, Japanese karate officials were able to impose a modern interpretation of karate and artificially placed it among Japan’s so-called traditional martial arts as an “invented tradition”—while actually creating only a new form of mass sport with a martial appearance, perfectly suited to the West and to a now-Westernized Japan.

Bruno Ballardini

8th Dan *Shorinji Ryu Zentokukai*

Former professor at the First University of Rome “La Sapienza”

President of the Italian Association for the Study of Ancient Karate

Coordinator of International Okinawa Shorinji-Ryu Tode Zentokukai in Europe

Author of the standing rubric “Karate Archeology” in *Bugeisha* magazine

Editorial manager of *Edizioni Mediterranee*

INTRODUCTION

NEW SIGNIFICANCE OF SHU HA RI IN POSTWAR KARATEDO—OR A MIS-TAKEN PARADIGM?

Shortly after the COVID-19 hysteria ebbed and things started settling down to a new normal, an intensive and months-long discussion arose amongst karateka I trained with. In ways surprising and unexpected, new opinions about how to approach our art were brought up, some of which we discussed for months. Not just that, we assessed new views that dared to contradict our decades-long training and teaching routines in long, at times cumbersome, conversations. We debated and tried out new kata applications, and we looked into developing *honto* kata.¹ We reconsidered the fighting benefit of formal *kumite* (sparring) arrangements and especially the lack thereof in some of them, and we examined new, individually created free-fighting sequences. So, what the heck happened here? Why were we suddenly having these talks, which, of course, were not negative as such; it was just that the point in time they occurred came as a surprise, at least to me.

It looks like an unexpected consequence of the COVID-19 lockdowns hit us here: months of quarantine added up to more than a year of imposed isolation during which karateka were forced to study their art individually, to the best of their knowledge, and isolated at home. Those who carried on with their studies that way and did not just abandon their training until it resumed in person used—beyond physical self-training—internet sites, blogs, and print and online publications to continue their education. They tried to figure out deeper aspects of their beloved art by themselves and on their own, without guidance from their sensei (teacher). As a result, not only were new interpretations experimented with, but misunderstandings were born as well, and all that was later brought back to the dojo (school) as new thoughts. Those new thoughts—some productive, some not so much—sparked our constructive and occasionally contentious discussions. The common denominator in these talks was how a specific traditional way

1 A *honto* kata is a traditional kata condensed into its fundamentals and core moves, without repetitions or side-mirrored applications, and thus revealing the skeleton of true intent, principles, and meaning of the kata and its techniques (Hayes 2018, pp. 146f).

to learn a karate system can limit a student's growth and exclude other input, thus limiting one's capabilities. Some of these disagreements could not be resolved, and, consequently, a group of students left the dojo and their karate association to establish their own new ways.

As I said, all that happened after the involuntary separation of students from their sensei, a separation which not only took place in the USA, but worldwide. Some sensei tried to bridge the gap by guiding their students' home training with recorded video clips or with online training sessions. That, however, only provided limited support, and it was not done specifically by Okinawan masters and their *honbu dojo* (style headquarters), the custodians of the art's genuine systems at its birthplace. In fact, Japan closed its borders to all foreigners, and for us Western students direct contact with our most senior Okinawan sensei was completely interrupted for almost three years as was contact with our domestic sensei for many months. In summation, all sensei-guided progression became unavailable for many. The related setback in qualification was significant but unavoidable since every practitioner knows how quickly "rust" builds up, neglect starts to set in, and individual idiosyncrasies begin to slip back in unnoticed—not to mention the fact that more than a few dojos lost students during the pandemic, some of which never reopened thereafter. Not all was bad though, because, as I said, in isolation new insights were discovered too and horizons were broadened.

Studying in seclusion myself, I specifically looked at the philosophical aspects of (*budo*) karatedo, at publications concerning topics like realistic fighting logic, surface (*omote*), hidden (*ura*), and true (*okuden*) principles in classic kata of (*bugei*) karate-jutsu²—and how karateka could grow into a better understanding of all this. In doing that, I realized that the Japanese developmental principle of *Shu Ha Ri* (explanation in next paragraph) was mentioned in modern karatedo publications, starting in the mid-1980s, but not before that time. And, interestingly enough, I did not find it mentioned in the classic karate texts accessible to me, or in the various prewar writings of karate masters. I, of course, cannot claim that there were none, I can only state that I did not find any. This baffled me

2 *Jutsu* is a Japanese term that was not in common use on Okinawa. But since the single term "karate" is used today to label different karate versions with different purposes, I use the term karate-jutsu deliberately and as a concession to today's unspecified use of the term karate to distinguish this Okinawan art centered on self-protection from its Japanese karatedo variation that emphasizes the path to self-perfection, and from modern sports-karate (Bayer 2023a, Chapter 1).

and sparked my interest in digging deeper. I started to query whether and when *Shu Ha Ri*, the traditional developmental concept of Japanese fine arts, was incorporated into karate, which I assumed may have happened as a part of Okinawan karate-jutsu's Japanization into karatedo, after the mainland discovered the fighting art of its province and pilfered it. And if that was the case, when, how, and why was it rediscovered for karatedo? The avenues for research from here on became clear to me.

The concept of *Shu Ha Ri* includes the notion that a practitioner's path to mastery goes through the three phases of *Shu* (follow the form, study the fundamentals), *Ha* (digress or break the form, understand its intent and function, apply the fundamentals), and *Ri* (transcend the form, create, and innovate). This path looked somewhat familiar to me, as I, at the same time I was beginning my investigations into *Shu Ha Ri*, was also reexamining the educational concepts I used in my previous academic teaching career in order to optimize my own karate teaching approach. This led to a lightbulb moment where I saw a possible correlation between postwar Western educational approaches and this Japanese principle of development drawn from the fine arts. I started conversations with colleagues to get their opinion on this possibility, conversations which are best summarized as "I never thought of that; interesting idea" in the words of Dr. James Hatch, 7th Dan *Chito Ryu*, *Sichibu Jyuku*, renowned educator and martial arts researcher. Chapter 6 will pinpoint parallels and disparities between Western educational approaches and Japanese teachings into which the *Shu Ha Ri* principle is woven.

Traditional dojos in the West use (almost) exclusively Japanese teaching concepts; they do not use Western ones. But considering the alarming loss of students in those dojos over the last decade, a decrease that contrasts with increasing student numbers in sports-karate where Western teaching concepts were added and are used, we suggest in Chapter 8 that such a solely Eastern training approach should be rethought. Our Western culture has changed considerably, and so have Western students' mindsets and attitudes. If a social organism, like a dojo, does not adapt to changed socio-cultural environments, it withers and eventually vanishes. Given that fact, and since the traditional karate philosophy is not self-explanatory to today's students, a bridge needs to be built between Eastern thought and those new Western minds and attitudes. Adding a Western teaching concept that reaches these minds could help build that bridge and help to link karate

training to students' other learning and leadership experiences in schools, colleges, and workplaces, which may eventually retain them. And, referring to *Shu Ha Ri*, Western teaching methods that go beyond instructor-centered modelling and mimicking seem to be the most promising way of mentoring and coaching advanced students in their *Ha* and *Ri* phases. Adding something Western to what's already there and done in the dojo is not replacing Eastern training routines; it is rather an add-on to ensure their acceptance and internalization in a way that best reaches Western minds.

The text will also explain why some Western martial artists hold a specific interpretation of the *Shu Ha Ri* concept in high regard, not so much because of its beneficial use in general, but because of its implied potential to bring about self-actualization.³ Whether and how the principle is indeed related to our Western understanding of self-actualization, or whether and how it is not, is a rather complex question, which we will answer in detail and, hopefully, sufficiently.

While diving deeper into the subject, the thought crossed my mind whether *Shu Ha Ri* perhaps could even lie at the root of our above-mentioned controversies about the way we approach our art and our new, often clashing opinions that dared to challenge our decades-long teaching and training routines. Could those new and opposed opinions in the dojo be a form of *Ha* (break the rules), or even *Ri* (transcend the rules)? Possible, yes, but this view did not sit well with me. It felt too simple and like some pieces of a jigsaw puzzle were still missing, and I decided that a better understanding *Shu Ha Ri* is of utmost importance in forming a sustainable opinion. I soon figured out that several considerations I developed in my previous books are related to this subject; those thoughts and background are woven into the text before you and connect all three books into a trilogy about karate's socio-cultural development, classic and modern interpretations of the art, and some possible misconceptions therein.

My suspicion rose that a modern rediscovery of *Shu Ha Ri* after WWII has to do with the modern transformations of self-protection karate-jutsu into a fine-art-like karatedo. To expressing something is the purpose of the fine arts, and artists strive to create original and innovative ways to communicate their personal view of things to

3 The psychological concept of self-actualization refers to the process by which individuals reach their full potential. The American psychologist Abraham H. Maslow popularized the concept; he saw self-actualization as fulfillment of one's greatest potential (Maslow 1943).

others. Picasso, for example, differentiated himself from other painters by developing his personal style to articulate his message and his personal views through his paintings. But Picasso, of course, never wrote a manual of practical instruction explaining how his approach could be used for a specific purpose. And this marks exactly an essential difference between a fine art—like painting, calligraphy, poetry, or acting—and an empty-hand self-protection craft like karate-jutsu. Karate-jutsu is not about “expressing something,” it is about defending against a (lethal) threat to you or your family. Consequently, when karate-jutsu’s purpose is changed and it is stripped of its martial content and turned into an athletic kata dance or into a path toward self-perfection, as was done in modern *budo* karatedo and in sports-karate, then these karate variations turn into fine arts that can be used to articulate a personal message, demonstrate one’s individual level of attainment, and be a means for self-actualization.

Therefore, it is understandable, as I soon found out, that *Shu Ha Ri* is not only unknown to many of my fellow karateka but that senior karate authorities, who emphasize karate as a self-protection art and not as a fine art, are unfamiliar with the concept as well. From the standpoint of these masters, a misunderstood *Ri* (transcend the form, create, and innovate) in *Shu Ha Ri* may appear as inappropriately questioning unquestionable basics. The opposing positions here are (a) that continuously practicing and diving deeper into a specific martial arts system equips karateka with all they need to understand what they are doing and to do it correctly in order to survive a lethal threat, versus (b), that at a certain point of their development a specific technique karateka used to train turns into a limitation and that they need to transcend the limits of their style or of their sensei to progress further. In the eyes of position (a) the second position (b) means that those karateka are simply reinventing the wheel, because their so-called new insights are not at all new, they are just new to them; they were included in the system they used to train in, and they’d have found those insights anyway if they’d continued to grow there. Chapter 5 will, among other things, deal with this aspect of possible *Shu Ha Ri* alibis for seemingly new, instead of “not new, just unknown to you,” insights.

Nothing could be farther from our intentions than to create conflicts when bringing *Shu Ha Ri* to the karatedo table; the opposite is actually true. In a phone conversation to discuss his thoughts on the subject, Sensei Jason S. D. Perry, 8th Dan, *Okinawa Shorinryu Karatedo*

Kobudo Kensankai, pointed out an important advantage for karateka studying their art today compared to senior karate authorities who did that some sixty or seventy years ago and that is today's abundance of excellent literature and internet resources. Over the past two or three decades, we have had those first-rate sources available, not only in Japanese but actually in our mother tongue. Classic and new texts were translated from Japanese, and plenty of other serious research and inquiry into deeper aspects of karatedo and karate-jutsu are easily accessible. While this makes it easier for us to study these days, it also requires a thorough evaluation of new concepts—well, in the case of *Shu Ha Ri*, not really new but with new significance—and their careful integration into the larger body of knowledge. Not everything new is better than tradition simply because it is newer, and not everything traditional is worse simply because it is older.

Integrating a relatively new construct into the martial arts has become a well-known phenomenon called “invented tradition” by researchers and was already done for karatedo with the concept of *Shin Gi Tai* (mind/spirit—technique—body), which seems to be a modern conception rather than a classic one (Quast 2023), and it was done for *kiai*, which seems to be useful in competition and grading but inappropriate for a secretly taught art that needed to remain undetected and was thus practiced in silence (Motobu 2024). *Shu Ha Ri* also looks like a modern development involving the transfer of a centuries-old Japanese fine arts principle to empty-hand fighting. To evaluate and analyze such a development is exactly what we intend to do here, because, as shown in chapter 5, there are serious pitfalls within the *Shu Ha Ri* concept, which can be used by karateka as an excuse for making mistakes, for reinventing the wheel, and for selling individual phantasies as genuine self-defense techniques. It will be shown further how the *Shu Ha Ri* developmental principle differs in its applications in classic (*bugei*) karate-jutsu for self-protection from its connotation in (*budo*) karatedo, where self-perfection instead of self-defense is pursued, and how both of these versions differ from evolutions in modern sports karate with its focus on competition, where the notion of *Shu Ha Ri* progression is rarely used, if at all.

In this sense, we can distinguish at least two conceptions of the use of *Shu Ha Ri*. One explains a karateka's development *within a karate-jutsu system*. With that understanding we may see the three phases like a crane's development from flapping its wings, to leaving the nest

and clumsily starting to fly, and finally to freely fly, swoop, dive, and evade without limitations. *Ri*-transcending *within a karate-jutsu* system would then mean to neither transcend the system as such nor to break away from your sensei. Sensei Jason S. D. Perry explains this progression in terms of a karateka's declining dependence on a teacher: "*Ri* is a state of independence. Where *Shu* is a state of dependence, *Ha* is the state of semi autonomy. *Ri* becomes the state in which the practitioner can learn and grow independent of a teacher. The art itself becomes the source of growth. That does not change the nature of the relationship between student and teacher."⁴ The other view, found these days mostly, but not exclusively, in the West, understands the phase of *Ri* as *breaking away from a style or from a sensei*. In other words, the first concept understands *Shu Ha Ri* as perfecting one's capabilities within the traditions of a classic fighting system; the second one understands mastery as an evolution to surpass a sensei and to perhaps invent a new fighting system. The first conception seems philosophically closer to Eastern Confucian roots, and the second one seems closer to Western individualism. The decision as to whether one of those two ways of understanding the concept is a misconception or not, or whether both conceptions can coexist or not, I leave to the reader. My job is to explain the two philosophies to the best of my abilities (though, eventually, I will not hide my point of view on this subject and clearly state my preference).

Now, last but not least: do considerations about *Shu Ha Ri* actually require that writers themselves have reached the *Ri* phase? Should it be "speaking from experience, looking back at the familiar [phase] rather than conjecture and opinion, trying to look forward into the unknown [one]," as Sensei Michael Clarke, 8th Dan *Goju Ryu Jundokan*, put it in one of our conversations about the subject?⁵ In my opinion, the answer here is twofold: "no" in one sense and "yes" in another, depending on whether we are considering intellectual comprehension or holistic understanding. In an intellectual, cognitive sense I'd say "no"; to analyze the concept, one need not have experienced *Ri* personally. "You don't have to have cancer to cure cancer" as the saying goes. So, in the sense of intellectual comprehension, there is no need to mystify *Ri* for insiders and to paint it as incomprehensible for outsiders. *Ri* can be

⁴ Email to me on 02/06/2024.

⁵ Email message to me dated 07/18/2023.

intellectually grasped by everyone, and today it is found verbatim and widely used in areas other than the martial arts, e.g., in the business world, which we will consider as an example in chapter 4. On the other hand, there is a difference between *cognitive/intellectual grasping* and *holistic understanding*. And in this latter sense of holistic understanding, my answer to the above question would be “yes”; I agree that personal competence with *Ri* best equips us to speak about the familiar.

To find our own place within the *Shu Ha Ri* phases, Sensei Michael Clarke suggests that “a large part of where we are in terms of *Shu Ha Ri* depends on what others can see in us” (ibid.). In this spirit, though I dare to write about the concept, my insight remains limited, as it always will be. My thoughts and conclusions are based on my personal level of understanding, and I am in no position to claim that my opinions are as relevant as the ones contributed by anyone else who studied martial arts for several decades. Having said that, I trust that my academic research background and my analytic skills as a scientist—in combination with my current level of understanding—allow some fruitful perspectives, because karateka’s general lack of familiarity with *Shu Ha Ri* alone justifies an attempt to shed more light on this Japanese developmental principle’s use in karate.

It is my distinct honor to have received helpful feedback and contributions from distinguished karate authorities and martial arts researchers during the ups and downs of diving into the subject before you. I cannot thank all of them enough for their invaluable input, their critiques, and their encouragement. I am not in the position to acknowledge those esteemed experts; I’d rather list their names here alphabetically by last name, as they speak loudly enough for themselves, and I’ll add their background when a name is referenced to for the first time. Chris Bates, Lara Chamberlain, Michael Clarke, Steven Franz, Franklin D. R. Hargrove, William R. Hayes, Professor Dr. Wolfgang Herbert, Dr. James Hatch, Terry Maccarrone, Jason S. D. Perry, Dr. Dan Smith, Noel Smith, and Thomas E. Ward, I am deeply grateful for your generous help and support. Thank you.

Dr. Hermann Bayer

Chapter 1

A Centuries-Old Japanese Fine Arts Principle Finds Its Way into Modern Karate

To gain some initial familiarity with the concept of *Shu Ha Ri*, it helps to look at the word itself, Sensei Jason S. D. Perry suggested to me, because we find these three characters in the Japanese language in a variety of everyday words with distinct meanings. “By deconstructing each of the *kanji*, one can further contemplate the building blocks that, when put together, make up the whole of the concept” (Waterfield 2014, p. 1). To do that, since looking at the etymology of Japanese terms exceeds my research skills, I point readers to Sensei Perry’s research (Perry 2018, pp. 300–305), and I include here his subsequent explanation of the *Shu Ha Ri* principle as a three-phased process of personal development, where “the first requirement of the student is obedience to strict teachings [*Shu* 守]; second is to overcome the teaching in the strict sense [*Ha* 破]; third is to separate from the rigid form of the art and find his or her way of expressing the art [*Ri* 離]” (ibid., p. 300; terms in brackets were added by me).

Sensei Lara Chamberlain, 8th Dan *Tiida Ryu* All Japan Budo Association, states that “the Chinese character *Shou* [*Shu*] is composed of two parts, ‘house’ and ‘law.’ Hence, the house of laws. The character means ‘to abide by; to defend.’ *Shou* (abide by) *Shi* (time) is being punctual, and *Shou* (abide by) *Xin* (trust) is being trustworthy. *Po* [*Ha*] is

composed of two parts, ‘stone’ and a phonetic part. It means ‘to break.’ *Li* [*Ri*] is composed of two parts, ‘bird’ and a phonetic part. It means ‘to leave; to depart.’”⁶

Dr. Wolfgang Herbert, Professor for Comparative Cultural Studies at the University of Tokushima/Japan, 6th Dan *Shotokan Karate-do* SKIF, explains that the *Shu Ha Ri* developmental principle is several centuries old and has its twofold origin in the Japanese fine arts. He points out that it is directly mentioned in a text written about *sado* (the way of tea) some five hundred years ago, on the one hand, and on the other, there is indirect reference in a text about the Japanese classic dance theater (*noh*), which was written some seven hundred years ago.⁷

Postwar *aikido* sources allege that *Shu Ha Ri* then found its way into this Japanese empty-hand martial art, which was developed in the 1920s by Ueshiba Morihei (1883–1969) as his self-labeled “art of peace” (Ueshiba 1992). Later, after WWII, *Shu Ha Ri* appears by name in *aikido* texts to explain developmental phases on a path to mastery (Endo 2005, n.p.). It is possible that *Shu Ha Ri* was also referred to by name in *aikido* before WWII; I just could not find any prewar publication using the term.

Referring to karate, it looks like not too many, if any, prewar publications refer explicitly to *Shu Ha Ri* either; otherwise, it would have been easier to locate some. But, again, just because I could not find them does not mean they do not exist, and the lack of records prior to the war should not necessarily lead to the conclusion that the concept was not in use then. But it seems safe to assume that the concept was not broadly discussed, and especially not on Okinawa in reference to the island’s local self-protection art karate-jutsu⁸ that was based on the

6 Message sent to me on 03/15/2024; italicizations in brackets are mine.

7 Email sent to me on 02/22/2024 in which Dr. Herbert wrote that tea master Sen no Rikyū (1522–1591) explains the path of *sado* in the form of a poem in his text *Rikyū Dōka* (利休道歌), where he writes, “Don’t forget the origination, even then when you, after preserving the forms and etiquette in every detail (守), separate yourself (破) and even liberate yourself from those (離).” It is Dr. Herbert’s opinion, which I share, that this poem includes *Shu Ha Ri* as a spiral of learning that holistically allows all three phases to exist simultaneously. Referring to the second root of *Shu Ha Ri* in *noh*, Dr. Herbert points to the text *Kadensho* (花伝書) by Zeami Motokiyo (1363–1443), where the latter deals with the three steps of prelude-evolution-finale as a universal conception of modulation. I translated Dr. Herbert’s German explanations into English.

8 In case you skipped the introduction: *jutsu* is a Japanese word that was not in common use on Okinawa. I use the term karate-jutsu deliberately and as a concession to today’s unspecified use of the term “karate” for all its different versions to distinguish the genuine Okinawan self-defense version from its Japanese karatedo variation and from modern sports-karate (Bayer 2023, Chapter 1).

Okinawa-specific, non-Japanese, universal principle of protecting oneself and others from physical and nonphysical harm (see next subchapter).

However, all the terms and most applications we use today in our karatedo practice are not of Okinawan origin anymore but are Japanese inventions and re-creations based on the Japanese karatedo principle of self-perfection. Hence, two differing concepts create a significant contradiction between Okinawan and Japanese karate interpretations, which suggests a broad and early use of the Japanese *Shu Ha Ri* concept on Okinawa as rather unlikely. This situation may, however, have changed over the decades during which there were increasing Japanese cultural impacts on Okinawan karate, even on the Ryukyus themselves. The concept was at least mentioned on Okinawa after WWII, as Sensei Terry Maccarrone, 9th Dan *Shorin Ryu* USKK, recalls: “It is basically a Japanese concept, but Hokama [i.e., Sensei Hokama Tet-suhiro; my addition] did mention *Shu Ha Ri* in deeper philosophical concerns. Shoshin Nagamine also mentioned this. But my sensei [i.e., Ueshiro Ansei, who brought Sensei Nagamine Shoshin’s *Matsubayashi Ryu* to the USA; my remark] never used that term as central to Okinawan *Te*.”⁹ Comparably, Sensei Dr. Dan Smith, the senior *Seibukan* karate authority in the USA, states that “I never heard the reference of *Shu Ha Ri* on Okinawa. I asked Shimabukuro Sensei decades ago about the meaning. His response was that it was difficult to explain in relationship to Okinawan karate.”¹⁰ Such a rather cryptic response by Sensei Shimabukuro suggests that the Japanese *Shu Ha Ri* concept was not really relevant for Okinawans and for their way of understanding karate, and it could well be that the concept of *Shu Ha Ri*, and the Japanese way of approaching karate as a whole, conflicts with the Okinawan approach, which is a possibility that will be evaluated further in the next subchapter.

It could well be that the *Japanese interpretation of karate as a fine art*, instead of the Okinawan interpretation of karate as an art for protecting oneself and others, was the entry point for the assimilation of *Shu Ha Ri* into Japanese karatedo. Sensei Perry questions whether “the Okinawans ever did view their own practice as an art that could be defined and therefore subjected to a concept like *Shu*?” and draws out

9 Message sent to me on 03/21/2024.

10 Message sent to me on 01/30/2024.

the implication that “if there were not accepted standards of practice, then it follows that *Shu* could not apply until the art was codified and systematized—a process that did not occur until later. So the idea that *Shu Ha Ri* is a foreign construct borrowed from Japan may be true; but then again isn’t the karate we practice?”¹¹ My response to the last question is “yes” for the majority of practitioners, but strongly “no” for an admittedly small but dedicated karateka minority. In my view, karate-jutsu in its initial Okinawan version as the way of protecting oneself and others, still exists in parallel to its systematized Japanese fine-art karatedo version of self-actualization and self-perfection. I do not see those two versions as the “transformation” of the Okinawan craft of karate-jutsu into the Japanese art of karatedo, but I see the creation of the latter as a newly constructed *budo* version in addition to its classic *bugei* or *jutsu* version, thus not representing an evolution or evolvement but embodying the conscious and deliberate generation of a different Japanese thing with its different purpose—newly created and parallel to the still-existing classic Okinawan version.

This classic Okinawan karate version is based on the universal principle of protecting others and oneself from physical and nonphysical harm; it is founded on a subcultural autonomous principle that differs from that Japanese interpretation of the art that an overwhelming majority of karateka practices today. The initial concept of Okinawan karate is not directly related to the Japanese *Shu Ha Ri* principle, which is perhaps one of the reasons why the Okinawans did not accept the latter as broadly as non-Okinawan karateka did. And, finally, while the Japanese *budo* philosophy is well-known, or at least known to more or less all karatedo practitioners, the just-mentioned genuine Okinawan concept of protecting others and oneself from physical and nonphysical harm is not as well-known, especially not in the West. Hence, it makes sense to reiterate it here as it sheds light on some primary reasons that explain the somewhat rare use of *Shu Ha Ri* in Okinawan karate-jutsu, which definitely contrasts with its broader use in Japanese karatedo.

11 Email sent to me on 02/07/2024.

Chapter 2

Shu Ha Ri Is a Japanese Socio-Cultural Concept, Not an Okinawan One

Though Okinawa is of course part of the Japanese nation, there were, and there still are, significant cultural peculiarities to be found in the local subculture of the Ryukyu islands, which, among other things, include different understandings of karate in the latter's traditional circles. Japan, the “karate-reproducing” country, however, is—and used to be—the superior political power governing the “karate-inventing” and culturally autonomous region of Okinawa and aimed at integrating the local self-protection art into the mainland's cultural traditions.

Okinawa Shows Subcultural Peculiarities That Appeared Inferior to Prewar Japan

Okinawa shows a dichotomy between culture and citizenship (Meyer 2007). On the one hand, Okinawa is, since the Satsuma invasion in the 1600s, a part of the Japanese nation, and on the other, it is an island far away from the mainland, with its own cultural roots, traditions, customs, and symbols; all of those developed while simultaneously serving the Chinese, Japanese, Korean, and Indonesian empires as their trading hub for centuries (Kerr 2018). During those centuries, Okinawa established its own subcultural identity. Within this

subculture, its local fighting system, *Ti*, is a paramount cultural symbol for Okinawan subcultural identity, and thus *Ti* was an important target for mainland Japan's efforts during the Meiji Period and in the following decades before WWII to create cultural homogeneity across the nation. In this integration process, the local Okinawan civilian self-protection art (which I call karate-jutsu) that developed out of *Ti* (which was initially a combat art for aristocratic security circles), was converted, "Japanized," into the *budo* art kara-te-do and reinterpreted with the Japanese philosophical *budo* framework as a means of character development and recreation. As a result, this new karatedo matched mainland Japan's other "*budoized*" martial arts in terms of purpose, structure, etiquette, and general philosophical approach.

The sociological/social borders of cultures and subcultures and their unique symbols, cultural assets, and heritage do not necessarily match the political borders of governments, and until today the Okinawans have not 100-percent assimilated into Japanese society (Hein/Selden 2003), which did not consider Okinawans as equal and that perpetuated a mindset of superiority even after the Ryukyus were no longer a colony and became a prefecture. But even at that time "Japanese rule in Okinawa had a touch of colonialism, particularly during the first two decades. Although nominally a prefecture, Okinawa remained under a separate system of administration. Most of the government agencies and institutions, starting with the prefecture office, were manned by appointees from Japan. Japanese merchants took control over the local economy and monopolized trade with other prefectures. Paternalism and arrogance characterized Japanese expatriates' attitudes toward the local people" (Meyer 2020, n.p.).

In spite of considerable efforts by Japan to assimilate the autonomous Okinawan subculture, including the Japanization of its subcultural symbol karate-jutsu (Johnson 2012), a wall remains up to this day, a dichotomy of culture and citizenship, and nothing indicates that it will disappear in the future (Meyer 2007). This means, that an Okinawan subcultural heritage and symbol does not necessarily represent the overarching culture of the nation—or, in other words, the subcultural symbol karate-jutsu may from the outside be incorrectly interpreted as the traditional national Japanese cultural symbol karatedo, which it is not (Bayer 2022). There is no traditional Japanese karate, only a traditional Okinawan one (Swennen 2006), because (1) the Japanized karatedo versions on the mainland were developed less than

Chapter 3

Based on Claims of Cultural Superiority, Japan Converts Okinawan Karate-jutsu into Karatedo and Inserts Japanese Philosophies

Although being a colonial possession of Japan since the early 1600s, Japan's occupying Satsuma aristocrats insisted that Okinawa was a foreign and barbarian land and forbade Okinawans from wearing Japanese clothing or adopting Japanese names. "For the following centuries mainland Japanese viewed Okinawans as second-class citizens and found them to be so different from themselves that they would challenge any assertions of a common identity" (Hein/Seldon 2003, p. 9). Even after the Ryukyu's political status was changed from colony to prefecture, the Japanese did not see the Okinawans as on a level with the Japanese, whether politically, socially, or culturally. "Although nominally a prefecture, Okinawa retained a semi-colonial status for two decades after its annexation in 1879. Despite the fact that Okinawan people accepted Japanese rule with little resistance, which ultimately turned into active support for the assimilation policy, Japanese policy makers never lost their distrust of Okinawan people. Similarly, Japanese society did not fully embrace them, perceiving them as

backward and inferior, and even questioning their Japanese-ness” (Meyer 2020, n.p.).

Beginning in the Meiji Period (1868–1912), Japan’s government sought to assimilate Okinawa Prefecture politically, ideologically, and culturally. The official rationale was that Okinawans needed to abandon all those aspects of their culture that kept them in their “backward,” inferior status and to embrace the superior culture of mainland Japan (Rabson 2012, p. 6), thus representing an attitude that would heavily impact karate’s development in the following years. Because karate was such an important symbol in Okinawan subculture, Japanizing this local self-defense art became a priority, not just for militaristic purposes, but also for the purpose of creating some kind of cultural homogeneity across all of Japan.

Prewar Japan’s Self-Proclaimed Cultural and Racial Superiority

What were the grounds for such an attitude of cultural and racial superiority, one might ask? Whereas the answer to this question is relatively well known for Nazi Germany—which was its ideology of an Aryan-Germanic super-race, and its quest to cure the world of racial mixtures that were supposed to be degenerative aberrations—the answer is not as well known for Japan. Hence, I will briefly summarize the findings of scientific research into where such beliefs about Japan’s cultural and racial superiority may come from. Researchers have identified the following factors:

- a) *The view of the Japanese race as unique and isolated*, having no known affinities with any other race. This view is promoted by most Japanese scholars, who classify Asian culture into the four areas of Islamic, Indian, Chinese, and—as a separate category on the same level as the other three—Japanese. In contrast, non-Japanese historians use three categories to classify Asian cultures, namely Islamic, Indian, and Chinese and see Japan not as a separate category but as a participant in Chinese civilization (Bellah 1965, p. 573).
- b) *The ancient mythological belief that Japan was created by divine beings* and that the Japanese are their descendants and thus indirectly linked to and protected by divinity. The concept gained further stature when the Mongols attempted twice to invade Japan but were routed both times by the “divine” intervention of seasonal typhoons.

- c) The widespread assumption that, because of its century-long isolation as an island state, *Japanese culture developed into something unique and different from all other cultures.*
- d) The fact that the *Japanese language is supposed to have a unique grammatical structure, vocabulary, and connotations* that are unparalleled in other languages. This is actually not completely true and represents an interesting switch of cultural beliefs in prewar Japan, after, for centuries, the Chinese language and philosophy used to be seen as the very benchmark for academic education.
- e) A *specific Japanese psychology*, where mutual interdependence of wishes and duties create a unique reciprocal form of human relationship in which boundaries between self and others become fluid, where on that account individualism cannot properly exist, and groupism will always prevail.

In summation, Japan has a history of self-acclaimed superiority that led to strong nationalism, which cumulated during and after the Meiji Restoration when Japan aimed to catch up with the Western powers. This superiority-based nationalism played a significant role in the project of unifying and strengthening the nation as well as in the justification of invading and occupying Pacific islands and large parts of Southeast Asia. The official ideology was that it was Japan's calling to a "righteous crusade" (Kerr 2018, p. 462) to (a) free this region from the influence of Western imperialists, from the barbarians who took advantage of Asia only to enrich themselves, and (b) to lift Southeast Asia's oppressed civilizations up to the standard of modern Japan through temporarily occupying and governing them, thereby reforming their systems, educating their populations, and releasing them into their new elevated self-regulated independence thereafter, closer to Japan's superior level. The Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895), the Russo-Japanese War (1904–1905), the country's participation in WWI, the preparation for the second war with China, its initiation in 1937, and Japan entering WWII by attacking Pearl Harbor in 1941—all represent facets thereof.

This political mindset of supremacy changed considerably after World War II and Japan's surrender, a change further hastened by deliberate attempts to politically distance the country from its prewar aggressive nationalism and militarism. So it is important to point out that Japan today is a diverse country with a wide range of attitudes and beliefs among its population. Though even in this time and age we find

some publications indirectly supporting those prewar views of racial superiority,⁴² it would be inaccurate to claim that this translates into a widespread attitude of supremacy. A better term than superiority, or even supremacy, for characterizing the attitude of many Japanese is that they are convinced of their own cultural “uniqueness.” That very attitude of uniqueness, however, is still today widespread. At a time when Japan surprised the world with its economic success after WWII, this attitude came in handy and was broadly used to further fertilize the nation’s endeavors. “It is almost an article of faith amongst Japanese that their culture is unique, not in the way that all cultures are unique, but somehow uniquely unique, ultimately different from all others ... Japanese are constantly persuaded of the specialness of their nation in schools and corporations and through the media and speeches by functionaries, whenever an opportunity arises for comparison with the outside world” (Van Wolferen 1990, p. 14).

Of course there are scientific studies debunking this component of Japanese self-understanding as unfounded—see, for instance *The Myth of Japanese Uniqueness* (Dale 2011)—but as always in history, politics, and life, it is not the facts as such that determine decisions, attitudes, or actions; all of these are rather determined by what people believe in, by their perceptions, and by their interpretation of facts that create their subjective “truth,” which may or may not correspond to objective reality. An entire library can be filled with psychological studies proving that beliefs determine human behavior, not facts.

Based on Self-Acclaimed Cultural Supremacy, Japan Redefines Karate Since Its Okinawan Version Embodied “Backwardness” in the Eyes of the Japanese

In the prewar period, Japan’s self-acclaimed cultural superiority was the official ideological basis of the nation’s militaristic regime. Consequently, after karatedo was introduced to mainland Japan during that time, Japanese officials representing that kind of mindset insinuated the necessity to elevate the Okinawan self-protection system into the refined “art” of

42 For instance the one titled “Why the Japanese Are a Superior People—The Advantages of Using Both Sides of Your Brain” (De Mente 2009), which, though it is a layperson’s psychological and neurophysiological speculation, was uncritically promoted in the newspaper *Japan Today* <https://japantoday.com/category/features/why-the-japanese-are-superior-people>.

Chapter 4

The Application of a Truncated Shu Ha Ri Concept in Modern Management

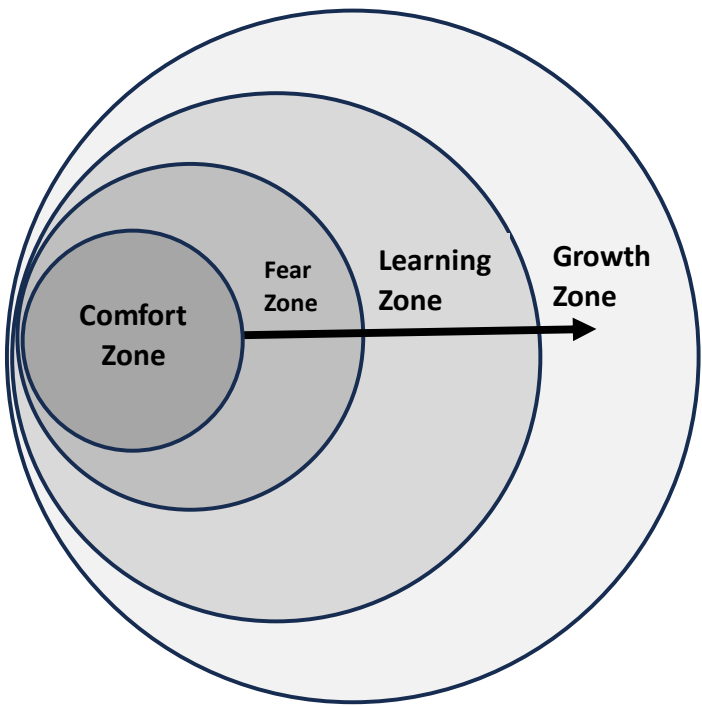
Interestingly enough, when I did my internet research for *Shu Ha Ri* in early 2024, it was not martial arts sites that popped up at first; instead, the vast majority of listed sites were, and still are, business- and management-related ones; they deal with consulting and coaching concepts, and they aim at developing project management skills, leadership capabilities, and software engineering skills.

In the business world, it all began in the mid-1990s, when a publication about “performance zones” contextualized performance with socio-psychological findings and introduced the relation of risk-taking, fear, entitlement, and performance into management theory. Thereafter, the phrase of “leaving one’s comfort zone,” which is today firmly embedded in cultural discourse, became popular. The term “comfort zone” itself was coined by management thinker Judith Bardwick (1991), and it refers to a person’s behavioral limits within emotional comfort zones in modern society. Within a specific zone, one operates in emotional safety without any need to take on much of a risk or face fear, though using only a reduced set of one’s behavioral options to deliver steady but at most mediocre performance. To encourage employees and their managers to deliver higher performance would mean that they would have to leave their comfort zones and take risks,

deal with emotional challenges, face and overcome their fears, and thereby advance into their individual learning and growth zones, as illustrated in image 9.

Though the model is not above critique—especially for its view of a limited fear zone instead of the need to overcome potential fear in all new challenges and specifically in the growth zone too—countless business consultants, coaches, and trainers jumped at the chance to use the model and came up with ideas for how to push managers, leaders, teams, and individuals out of their comfort zones and to get them to enter their learning and growth zones.

Image 9: Bardwick’s Model of Comfort, Learning, and Growth Zones



Business Consultants Discover Shu Ha Ri

It is not exactly clear which of those consultants first came up with the idea of connecting such Western developmental models with the Japanese developmental *Shu Ha Ri* principle. However, since those consultants who refer to *Shu Ha Ri* call it an ancient Japanese martial arts principle (which is incorrect) and not an ancient Japanese fine-arts principle (which it actually is), it seems safe to assume that such a connection was introduced by someone who either practices some kind of a modern Japanese *budo* art or at least knows a bit about it.

During my own professional career in the business world, I personally experienced the decades-long fascination with, and the success of, Japanese business philosophies, models, and strategies. Starting in the mid-1980s, certain concepts—like TQM (total quality management), which called for management to focus on enterprise-wide, consistent strategies instead of segmented approaches, and its *kaizen* (continuous improvement); JIT (just-in-time-production), which reduces warehousing cost, and its *kanban* (scheduling system); LM (lean management) that needs fewer supervisors and managers, and its *ikigai* (aligning activities with one's passions, values, and skills)—actually revolutionized traditional Western ways of management and production. Japan's rapid growth after WWII, in some markets almost miraculous, and its new economic significance with considerable influence on global trade, has not gone unnoticed. The Japanese way of achieving lasting success became the newly established and accepted benchmark for Western managers.

Hence, any addition of “something Japanese” to a management philosophy became a good idea, and the arguments of consultants and coaches about selling their services, even if they were just simple exercises in rhetoric, could never go too far when they included a Japanese concept. So it does not come as a surprise that over the last two decades new consulting schemes have popped up that rely on an almost mystical conception of *Shu Ha Ri*, which then spread amongst coaches and consultants like wildfire. The common denominator of related training and professional development is based on the smart concept of agile pedagogy (Höhne et.al. 2017) and the corresponding “agile mindset” that is needed to come up with creative solutions, and that—so goes the idea—can be achieved by growing through the phases of *Shu*, *Ha*, and *Ri*. Hence, in the business world the concept was understood as a pattern of development that led to greater agility.

Following its implementation into software development around 2001, we find *Shu Ha Ri* today embedded in all kinds of skill development, as image 10 shows. This list is a random overview illustrating *Shu Ha Ri*'s widespread use; it is not a complete one, as my first unspecified internet searches came up with more than fifty business-related *Shu Ha Ri* entries.

Image 10: Examples* of Shu Ha Ri Use in the Business World

Management	Management 3.0 Leadership Training for Managers (n. d.). <i>Building learning organizations and Agile adoptions always starts with Shu Ha Ri.</i> https://management30.com/blog/shu-ha-ri-agile-leadership/ .
Organizational Development	DiBartolomeo, Milvio (n. d.). The Shu Ha Ri mindset. https://www.praxisframework.org/en/resource-pages/dibartolomeo-shu-ha-ri..
Software Engineering	Fowler, Martin (2014). Shu Ha Ri. https://martinfowler.com/bliki/ShuHaRi.html . Gaurav, Menon (2020). Shu Ha Ri—Disciplined Learning and Problem Solving Approach. An Agile approach to learning and how to correlate it with design thinking. https://medium.com/agileinsider/shu-ha-ri-disciplined-learning-and-problem-solving-approach-91266593824b .
Coaching	Kudinov, Alex (2020). Shu-Ha-Ri of Professional Coaching. https://www.scrum.org/resources/blog/shu-ha-ri-professional-coaching . Goncalves, Louis (2023). Shu Ha Ri Agile A Fantastic Tool For Agile Coaches. https://agilemastery.org/en/blog/shu-ha-ri-agile-coaches .
Team Development & SCRUM **	Novack, Jason (2021). Shu Ha Ri: An agile adoption pattern. https://www.accenture.com/us-en/blogs/software-engineering-blog/shuhari-agile-adoption-pattern . Angel, Skip (n.d.) The Art of Shu Ha Ri in Scrum—Scrum from Student to Master. https://resources.scrumalliance.org/Article/art-shu-ha-ri-scrum .
Project Management	Ivan, F. (2015). Becoming Agile with Shuhari. United States: Project Management Institute. https://www.pmi.org/learning/library/becoming-agile-with-shuhari-9649 .
* All sites retrieved on 02/13/2024	
** SCRUM is a term from the game of Rugby that denotes a cooperative play of several players.	

Misunderstandings of Shu Ha Ri in Business Applications

Unfortunately, however, hidden in *Shu Ha Ri* business applications are some essential shortcomings that reveal how the concept is gravely misunderstood there. A first misconception manifested itself when *Shu Ha Ri* was linked to Bardwick's model of developmental zones, which was introduced at the beginning of this chapter. *Shu* was allied with the comfort zone, *Ha* with the learning zone, and *Ri* with the growth zone, thus representing an attribution that reveals gross misunderstanding,

Chapter 5

Misinterpretations of Shu Ha Ri May Allow Excuses for Laxity

Since karate-jutsu and its predecessors have been practiced for centuries, it seems safe to assume that there is not one single move that would not have been used by somebody else during all that time, because in delving into the mechanics of the human body, we realize that there's a finite number of ways to move the arms and legs. And since the biomechanical and physiological basis of human movement did not change much over those centuries, supposedly nothing is really new in karate-jutsu, except those things that have been forgotten over the course of its transformation into a *budo* art, or those things that were deliberately not taught to non-Okinawans. But seemingly forgotten aspects of the art may be still included in those classic moves and authentic kata some of us practice today, and serious efforts were and still are undertaken to discover those inclusions. Important research in that sense is conducted and published on the internet as well as in print.

In other words, the claim by some karateka to having invented or created something completely new is most certainly invalid. Their creations were only new to them until they figured something out that somebody else had already figured out a long time ago. What to some extent may distinguish karate styles are the principles of application and their significance in various fighting scenarios. Beyond those differences, as our earlier tree metaphor illustrated, the main branches of the tree, i.e., the karate-jutsu umbrella styles, are united in its trunk of

universal self-protection. And eventually, as mentioned earlier as well, every karate-jutsu system with its purpose of universal self-protection is—at least in my opinion—comparable to a language. It is complete as it is and based on identical fundamentals, just as all languages are based on comparable linguistic fundamentals.

A karate-jutsu system does not need new components to be added by individual karateka, just like a language does not need new grammars added by individual speakers. Instead, all different languages can be used alike, as they are, to perfectly articulate the same thing; and if indeed some new words or phrases are added, that would not change the language as it is. To continue the language metaphor, there is enough room for countless masterly poets to use the same language without the need to create a new language to compose their masterpieces. Likewise, all karate-jutsu systems can be successfully used, as they are, for self-protection, and there is enough room for countless masters within the same system without the need to break away from it. To continue the language metaphor even further, modern changes to a language usually do not increase its complexity and rather alter the nature of its proper use, as the introduction of slang phrases and grammar simplifications into American English shows. That introduction is a regrettable development that matches the simplification of karate-jutsu's complexity through karate-do inventions and creations.

The view presented here, however, will not be shared by everyone, but perhaps we can all find some common ground by looking at the seemingly undisputable fact that everything completely changes for karate when money becomes involved—when, for instance, sensei need to earn a living through teaching the art and must therefore separate themselves from competitors. Comparably, that is the case as well when karate associations need to recruit paying members to be able to disburse their leaders and hire full-time officials.

Karatedo's Commercialization May Encourage Interpretations of Shu Ha Ri as Breaking Away

If karate is a sensei's only source of income in a competitive market, it becomes essential for that sensei to find a market niche, a USP (unique selling point), that allows him to point out how his own karate approach, in addition to the general benefits of practicing the art, is

Chapter 6

Parallels and Differences Between Shu Ha Ri and Western Educational Concepts and Their Probable Mutual Supplementation

(with contributions by Thomas E. Ward)

Sensei Tom Ward, 7th Dan *Shorin Ryu Shorinkan*, recalls how he, “as a martial arts instructor with a few years of experience under my black belt, became obsessed with how I could convey more advanced meanings, philosophies, and skill sets to my students. As a formally trained educator I assessed how I was being taught and what influences that had on me and my understanding of my art, and I learned about the Japanese martial arts concept of learning referred to as *Shu Ha Ri*. As a well-disciplined student I often felt caught in this description of development. When should one move from stage to stage? At what point can a student be considered to have enough understanding to accept other teachings? When is a student sufficiently grown so that he is not considered impertinent for doing such things? As I have grown, developed, and matured, I’ve found that those questions are only answered ‘from within’ [meaning by personal insights within a karateka’s mind].” The notion of finding answers “within” is something of a double-edged

sword in that answers may indeed be found within, but there is no measure for assessing the truth and reliability of what are essentially subjective claims. They may reflect reality in many cases but may turn out to be wishful thinking in others as well.

Therefore, it might be wise to cross-check students' personal interpretations against the insights of experienced karateka, who possess the real-life combat skills needed to distinguish effective self-defense techniques from mere illusions. The neutral yardstick (or at least benchmark) for measuring the soundness of subjective interpretations mentioned earlier was "measurable self-defense impact" (see the subsection "The Yardsticks That Measure the Adequacy of Interpretations of Karate Moves" in Chapter 1). Again, and as pointed out several times in this text, such a validation of individual moves is only possible when karate is interpreted in its *bugei* version of karate-jutsu, as an art for universal self-protection with unpretentious fighting moves. It is quite different for the fine art of karatedo, where individual karateka may express themselves through changing the purpose of moves from self-defense to self-articulation. The latter are personal moves and as such not really measurable (except, perhaps, in terms of how well they match a sensei's personal ideas), whereas moves are only measurable neutrally, in an objective way, when they are being used as means of self-protection, as in karate-jutsu.

To be in a better position to answer related questions, let us first look a bit closer at the educational methods we use in Western education to develop skills, and let us then compare these Western approaches to the Japanese developmental principle *Shu Ha Ri*.

Modern Western Educational Concepts

Acquiring a skill or learning a subject is more complex than one may first imagine, and the process of teaching a skill or a subject is even more complex. Teachers have to decide what they are trying to achieve with their students (objectives), how they are going to accomplish that objective (methodology), and then find a way of measuring to what degree they've been successful (assessment). Such an instructional design is often surprisingly difficult to put into words.

In the mid-1950s, the educational psychologist Benjamin S. Bloom chaired a committee of educators that did just that. It created a

classification of six learning levels to help instructors to better structure their teaching and their students' learning (Bloom 1984). The six levels of the resulting "Bloom's Taxonomy" are:

- Remember (recognizing and recalling)
- Understand (interpret, exemplify, classify, summarize, infer, compare, explain)
- Apply (execute and implement according to learned information)
- Analyze (differentiate, organize, and attribute)
- Evaluate (check and critique)
- Create (generate, plan, and produce)

While the specific stages and the terminology differ between this Western model and *Shu Ha Ri*, the two approaches share the idea of progressing from a beginner's level to a more advanced and independent stage. Both frameworks emphasize the importance of building a solid foundation, of developing skills and understanding through practice, and of eventually reaching a stage where creativity and innovation can thrive.

Though the committee of educators developed approaches for all three learning areas of the cognitive, the affective, and the psychomotor, Bloom's Taxonomy is mostly used in the cognitive area, about which Bloom himself wrote and edited the first handbook out of a series of three. The model didn't fare as well, however, in the effort to describe emotional learning or the acquisition of physical skills. Other educational concepts were formulated to fill that gap and better cover psychomotor learning areas, which apparently are more difficult to put into words for Western educators than cognitive approaches.

To acquire physical skills, students first imitate actions shown to them. After repeated attempts and practice, they may move to a level of skill where they can manipulate those movements. Here they can change the rhythm of the movement, change the speed of performance, or make other adjustments to the moves without much substantial change or fundamentally altering them. As the process continues, students begin to increase the precision of their movement. In basketball, their shots become more accurate with practice. In skiing, they're able to make more acute turns. In martial arts, their movements are crisper and are performed with more focus and power. Eventually, the student

begins to articulate the movements, perhaps using movements in new ways or using already-learned movements in different applications. The movements gradually become natural and are done without conscious awareness. Not only are they performed almost automatically, but they are also applied in novel situations without forethought.

Such a process is reflected, for instance, in the five stages of the “Dreyfus Model of Skill Acquisition” that was formulated about twenty-five years after Bloom’s Taxonomy (Dreyfus 1980). This model for developing professional skills introduces the five stages of

- Novice (needs instruction)
- Beginner (needs only direction)
- Competent (can be expected to work independently)
- Proficient (will routinely deliver above expectations)
- Expert (will define new standards and go beyond existing interpretations)

The Dreyfus model seems to work well for acquiring professional, work-related skills and for executing a craft; but when it comes to its application in the martial arts—though it includes some psychological adaptations and affective developments—it does not adequately integrate the underlying martial values, the mental and spiritual components, and the progress that consists in acquiring skills through repeating phases rather than by moving up a hierarchy of levels, which all are essential to the process of skill development.

In spite of several other educational concepts having been formulated in recent years (e.g., SOLO taxonomy,⁴⁶ Dee Fink’s taxonomy,⁴⁷ Edys Quellmalz’s framework of thinking skills⁴⁸), Bloom’s trailblazing cognitive-centered taxonomy remains by far the most used model in the US, in Europe, and in other Western educational systems.

⁴⁶ <https://www.johnbiggs.com.au/academic/solo-taxonomy/>.

⁴⁷ <https://clt.champlain.edu/kb/dee-finks-taxonomy-of-significant-learning/#:~:text=Fink%20proposes%20that%20significant%20learning%20occurs%20when%20six,significant%20the%20learning%20will%20be%20for%20the%20student.>

⁴⁸ Quellmalz, Edys et.al. (1995). “School Based Reform: Lessons from a National Study; a Guide for School Reform Teams” (Reprint: University of Michigan Library).

Chapter 7

The Essence of Shu Ha Ri Is Its Coexisting “Trinity of Phases”

We now know that *Shu Ha Ri* is a universal principle that describes any type of personal growth and that it is a developmental principle in the Japanese fine arts that can be applied to many disciplines. The principle describes the natural order in which mastery can be attained, given enough effort, time, analysis, and deliberate practice. We furthermore know that it is more adequately understood as a revolving synthesis of coexisting developmental phases instead of those levels or stages we predominantly associate with Western educational concepts. And, finally, we know that the growth process is never finished.

Trinity of Coexisting Phases in Shu Ha Ri Instead of Skill Levels

After integrating the insights of Sensei Jason Perry, Sensei Lara Chamberlain, Shifu Hong Yi-Xiang, and Shifu Hong Ze-Han into my own research and conclusions, I hold that the *Shu phase of dependence* characterizes a karateka’s learning as abiding by the rules; they learn the forms, the “surface appearances” or external mechanics of what they are doing, and they remember those forms bit by bit through repetition. When the time comes, they have internalized all forms and rules and can abide by them—and when *Shu* is achieved that way, the *Shu*

phase is finished, and karateka enter into the *Ha phase of semi-autonomy*. They now learn the intentions behind the forms, the function of moves including the common denominators of the fundamentals underlying them, and the initially rigid rules become more flexible, applied to every case but a practitioner recognizes those cases where an exception has to be made. When the time comes, karateka apply fundamental principles automatically and competently; they see more than one aspect to every form and rule—and when Ha is achieved that way, the Ha phase is finished, and karateka enter into the *Ri phase of independence*. They now learn the dynamics of change and adaptability to naturally employ form and intent to any circumstance, and their responses become second nature. Now the *Ri* phase is finished, and a karateka enters into a new dimension of *Shu*, and so on and so forth.

In the unconscious actions and responses in the *Ri* phase, the three core components of mastery come into play, which I illustrated in my second book with the example of playing chess (Bayer 2023a, pp. 112ff). I will briefly summarize them here: beginners may think through one move, including its implications and an opponent's possible reactions. Advanced players may be able to think through two, three, or even more moves. But there are chess masters who do not analyze “sequentially,” i.e., step by step, and think in detail through all possible moves. They process the information on the board differently, holistically, including its inherent patterns and all possible developments. Such a level of mastery is the combination of three core components:

1. *Holistic perception*, complete and simultaneous, comprehending the big picture, its inherent patterns, and all possible developments. This competency can be illustrated by the metaphor of climbing the highest tree in a forest to look to get oriented and gain an entirely new understanding of one's surroundings. Now “the big picture”—the forest, the “totality” of the landscape beyond the forest, and the many details close by—can be seen as a whole. Such new insight changes one's perspective irreversibly and completely.
2. *Mental storage of concepts in a complex, cross-linked hierarchy*, as an organized scheme of deep penetration and advanced understanding of the subject. The deeper the penetration and understanding, the more *the complexity of reality reduces itself into a limited number*

of constitutive fundamentals. For a master, it is obvious how the combinations of a handful of core concepts, or fundamentals, explain all the particulars of an art—just as all the countless hues of printed works of art are reducible to combinations of only four basic printing colors, blue, yellow, red, and grey.

3. *Automatic, habitual, subconscious actions and reactions rooted in the complete calmness of an “empty mind,”* honed through decades of training where moves and concepts are tested in all possible circumstances.

When *Ri* is achieved, the *Ri* phase is finished, and *karateka* enter into a new dimension of *Shu*. In other words, improvements and advanced skills gained in a later phase redefine what a practitioner did before in a less advanced manner, continuously changing everything in a never-ending spiral of evolution, where all phases simultaneously coexist (see image 12).

During this journey, one can achieve complete self-control of body and mind, thereby gaining master over emotions like fear and anger that often blind us to the reality of a situation. The resulting applications and concepts become a master’s store house of spot-on reactions to all kinds of attacks, and the unconscious, accurate application of concepts eventually becomes habit. Moves happen automatically, at reflex speed, efficiently and unconsciously guided by an empty mind.

Image 12: The “Trinity” of the Shu Ha Ri Developmental Principle

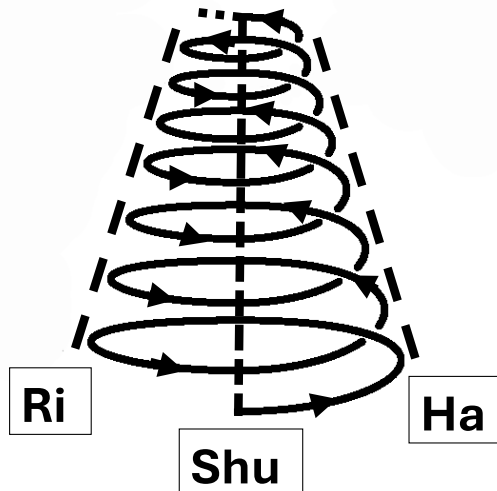


Image 14: Stepping into a Horse Stance in Shorin Ryu Karate-jutsu (left) and Doshinkan Karatedo (right) Versions of Pinan Sandan



Chapter 8

Conclusion and Consequences

Shu Ha Ri is a concept that first appeared in the Japanese fine arts several centuries ago. As a way of understanding personal growth, the model suggests that karateka move through three phases: learning the forms and fundamentals of the art (*Shu*); over comprehending the intentions behind the forms and focusing on (experimenting with) applications (*Ha*); into transcending the initial forms and creating their own ways of preserving fundamental traditions (*Ri*). Since the three phases are of a repetitive character, improvements and advanced skills that are gained in a succeeding phase trickle back into what a practitioner did before, optimizing executions continuously in a never-ending spiral of evolvement. In other words, all phases coexist simultaneously and form a trinity of revolving phases, which allows karateka to continuously deepen their understanding and mastering of the art.

With a Western mindset, many may see such a development as a karateka's path through ranks and belts up to mastership, to the top-level of a stairway of skills and status. "Although it's not impossible for Westerners to grasp such concepts [like *Shu Ha Ri*—my addition]," says Sensei Michael Clarke, "it is made more difficult by the world we grew up in and the 'values' ingrained into us over time. In the end, we're talking about something we can either see in someone, or not. We're talking about human values that can't be measured in terms of 'status' without killing the value of what we saw. Once we assign status to the various stages of *Shu Ha Ri*, the concept becomes meaningless ... but the more a

person believes (holds on to) the notion of *Shu Ha Ri*, the less likely they are to get beyond the early stages of learning.” *Ri* competence cannot be grasped through the Western concept of status; it embodies something different, a holistic personal evolution, where all three phases together form a trinity and coexist simultaneously.

Though keeping in mind that “when dealing with foreign philosophies we are often at a disadvantage because there is nothing that we can readily compare them to” (Waterfield 2014, p. 1), we do not want to “mystify” the *Shu Ha Ri* concept, especially its *Ri* phase, or label it as “incomprehensible” for outsiders. *Ri* competence is achievable (and to be found) in areas other than the martial arts as well, and not only in Japan. The *Shu Ha Ri* principle has become widespread, for instance, in today’s business world within the context of agile learning after it was introduced about two decades ago in software engineering, project management, and general leadership skills development.

Since considerations about *Shu Ha Ri* in karate are primarily found after WWII, it could well be that the Japanese interpretation of karate as a fine art—as the *budo* art of karatedo with the purpose of achieving self-perfection, which contrasts with the Okinawan interpretation of karate-jutsu as an art for protecting oneself and others—opened up Japanese karatedo for *Shu Ha Ri* application. Based on Japan’s self-acclaimed racial and cultural superiority at that time, the Okinawan way of self-protection embodied backwardness in the eyes of mainland Japan’s political and martial arts officials. They redefined karate-jutsu as the *budo* art of karatedo for self-perfection and integrated it into the mainland’s system of *budo* along with the latter’s philosophical undergirding. This new concept of karatedo allowed for the application of mainland Japan’s *Shu Ha Ri*, Zen meditation, and Buddhism, which differ considerably from anything in Okinawa’s socio-cultural traditions and from the Okinawan universal principle of protecting oneself and others that guided karate’s practice and application there. The pragmatic, outcome-focused Okinawan fighting approach that prioritizes results over the way to get there is now converted into a Japanese fine art that prioritizes the execution of forms over their effectiveness in a fight.

The Japanization of Okinawan karate is accompanied by the mainland’s introduction of and request for karate styles (initially, there were no styles in Okinawan karate, there was only the unifying principle of protecting oneself and others). Japanization is accompanied further by

LIST OF PHOTOS AND GRAPHS

<i>Title</i>	<i>P</i>	<i>T</i>	<i>G</i>	<i>Page</i>
Image 1 <i>The Shu Ha Ri Developmental Principle</i>			X	14
Image 2 <i>Unity of Constant and Change in Okinawan Karate-jutsu</i>			X	20
Image 3 <i>Tuite Move to Damage Joints in Traditional Passai Sho versus Arm Circle without Martial Purpose in Modern Passai Sho</i>	X			31
Image 4 <i>Swastika Is A Religious Symbol in Many Asian Cultures</i>	X			42
Image 5 <i>Tentative Shu Ha Ri Interpretation for Today's Three Main Karate Variations</i>		X		44
Image 6 <i>Today's Three Non-Japanese Umbrella Karate Styles on Okinawa</i>			X	55
Image 7 <i>Ferocious Warriors (Nio) Protect the Buddha</i>	X			78
Image 8 <i>Sensei Frank Hargrove and Sensei Noel Smith in the Late 1970s</i>	X			83
Image 9 <i>Bardwick's Model of Comfort, Learning, and Growth Zones</i>			X	92
Image 10 <i>Examples of Shu Ha Ri Use in the Business World</i>		X		94
Image 11 <i>Implicit Philosophies in Shu Ha Ri and in Western Educational Concepts</i>			X	114
Image 12 <i>The Holistic Trinity of the Shu Ha Ri Developmental Principle</i>			X	121
Image 13 <i>Coexistence of Contradictions in Chinese Philosophy</i>			X	123
Image 14 <i>Stepping into a Horse Stance in Shorin Ryu Karate-jutsu and Doshinkan Karatedo Versions of Pinan Sandan</i>	X			126
Image 15 <i>Karate-jutsu and Karate-Do Together Constitute the Whole of the Art in Modern Times</i>			X	139
Image 16 <i>Eastern and Western Concepts Together May Constitute the Whole of Teaching Traditional Karate in the West</i>			X	152

INDEX

- agile mindset 93
- agile pedagogy 93
- Ancestor Worship 5
- art of peace 2
- Asato Anko 6
- athletes create an impression 35
- athletic gymnastics 22
- athletic kata dance xxv
- avoidance 101, 102
- backwardness 75
- become the model 17, 59, 108
- become the teacher 17, 59, 108
- big picture 120
- bird metaphor 15
- Bloom's taxonomy 111, 112, 114, 116
- body-weight power 27, 31, 32
- break away from your sensei xxvii, 12
- breaking the form 43
- breaking with tradition 26, 56
- Bubishi 159, 174
- Buddhism 35, 39, 41, 78
- budo 75, 76
- budo karatedo xxv, 27
- bujutsu 75
- bushido 75, 77
- calligraphy xxv, 22
- center of gravity 31, 32
- character development 77
- ch'i 153, 167
- Chibana Chosin 19, 69, 99
- Christianity 39
- classic Okinawan karate-jutsu 78
- codifying 7
- cognitive xxvii, 111, 112
- competition showmanship 22
- concept of self-protection 77
- Confucianism 62, 78, 122, 153, 154
- Confucian roots xxvii, 25
- contradiction between change and preservation 124
- cross-linked concepts 120
- culture of conformity 25
- Dai Nippon Butoku-Kai 76
- development within a karate-jutsu system xxvi
- Dreyfus Model of Skill Acquisition 112
- ego 26, 100, 101, 102, 107, 122
- emotional learning 111
- empty-hand self-defense craft xxv
- empty mind 40, 121
- Endo Seishiro 36
- enlightenment 28, 36, 37, 38, 41, 154
- esoteric 35, 40
- essence of a traditional kata 125
- fantasy moves 21, 26, 27, 43
- fine art xxv, 4, 19, 23, 27, 33, 43, 65
- fine art of self-development 27, 33, 43
- frustration tolerance 102
- Fukyu kata 61
- Funakoshi Gichin 21, 75
- fundamentals 121
- giri 62, 64
- Gorin kata 61
- groupism 25
- hidden applications 25
- Hiroshi Kinjo 10, 36
- holistic concept 14
- holistic perception 120
- Holistic thinking 123
- holistic understanding xxvii
- Hong Yi-xiang 13, 56, 60
- humility 19, 77, 101

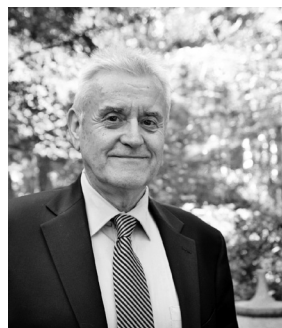
- ikebana 65
- individual expression of the art 16
- individual innovations 21
- individual interpretations of forms 103
- individualism 25, 102
- individually differing interpretations 31
- industrialization 99
- inherent patterns 120
- intellectual comprehension xxvii
- invent a new fighting system xxvii
- Isshin-Ryu 56
- Itosu Anko 78
- Japanese business philosophies 93
- Japanese cultural values 26
- Japanese fine arts principle xxiii, xxvi, 65
- Jeet Kun Do 24
- JKA 34, 77
- kado 65
- karate as a fine art 3
- karate as a self-defense art xxv
- ki 153, 167
- kumite 35
- learning objectives 113
- Lee, Bruce 24, 25, 29, 170
- lethal encounters 23
- logic and reality of fighting 31
- long-standing protocol 59
- Mainstream karate 18
- market niche 98, 99
- martial art in name only 24
- martial art of scholars 24
- martial arts in name only 23
- martial arts of scholars 23
- mass product 99
- Matsumura Sokon 23, 35
- meditative philosophy 19
- Meiji Period 72
- mimic the teacher 17, 59, 65, 108
- mind over matter 38, 41
- modern karate reality 106
- monopolistic competition 99
- moral standard 154
- mysticism 35, 37
- Nakazato Shugoro 60, 69, 115
- narcissism 100, 101
- national cultural symbol 76
- nationalism 73
- nerve strikes 77
- never change kata 124
- occupation of Southeast Asia 73
- Okinawan Karate-Jutsu 77, 78
- Okinawan sub-cultural symbol 76
- Original Seven 115
- outcome is prioritized over the form 7
- overarching unity 123, 124
- Passai 15, 30, 105
- path towards self-perfection xxv, 28
- personal interpretations 33, 43, 58, 103
- physical and non-physical harm 4
- physiology of the human body 23
- Picasso, Pablo xxv, 23
- pressure points 77
- psycho-motoric learning 111
- qi 153, 167
- racial superiority 72, 74
- real fight 16, 103, 162
- recreational athletics 19, 29
- re-inventing the wheel xxv, xxvi, 27
- relationship between student and teacher xxvii
- resilience 102
- second class citizens 71
- self-absorption 107
- self-acclaimed superiority 73
- self-actualization xxiv, 4, 18, 27, 28, 33, 36, 37, 40, 43, 65, 75, 100, 106
- self-control 121

- self-perfection xxii, xxvi, 3, 4, 19, 29, 33, 36, 43, 76, 77
- self-protection xxvi, 4, 6, 7, 16, 19, 23, 29, 33, 42, 58, 60, 61, 76, 98
- senior karate authorities xxv, xxvi
- senpai/kohai system 26, 62
- Shimabukuro Eizo 56, 57
- Shimabukuro Tatsuo 56
- Shin Gi Tai xxvi, 18
- Shudokan 36, 160, 166, 170, 188
- simultaneous existence of phases 15
- socio-cultural background 153
- sports-karate xxii, xxv, 2, 24, 29, 30, 34, 35, 42, 43
- standardization 7
- state of dependence xxvii
- state of independence xxvii
- state of semi autonomy xxvii
- subcultural identity 77
- supplier driven market structure of Okinawan masters 99
- systemizing 7
- Taoism 62, 153, 154
- three-phased growth path 11
- time capsule of fighting information 125
- Tomaya Kanken 36, 60
- totality 120
- transcend the system xxvii, 17, 42
- true martial arts 23
- trunk of the tree 106, 125
- Uchinaguchi 5, 8
- Ueshiba Morihei 2
- underlying concepts 8
- understand the intentions of the teachings 17, 59, 65, 108
- universal self-protection 6, 55, 59, 78, 98, 110
- USP 98, 106
- warrior spirit 76
- Western educational concepts 14, 119
- Western individualism xxvii, 18, 43, 64
- Yzong Tangschou 13
- Zen 19, 29, 36, 37, 77, 78
- Zen meditation 37, 38, 40

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Hermann Bayer, PhD

Hermann is a long-time karate practitioner, scientist, and author, who holds degrees in economics, sociology, psychology, and business administration. He worked in German and US universities for eighteen years as a researcher, professor, campus dean, and multi-site dean. For another twelve years, Hermann was the CEO and executive coach of a German coaching and consulting firm. In addition, he had ten successful years of self-employment, nine years working in the manufacturing industry, and two years of serving in the (West) German army's corps of engineers. He immigrated to the USA in 2005, where he later on changed his life priorities to practicing and studying karate and kobudo (weapons) full-time.



The author of several books and numerous articles on industrial relations and on coaching and consulting, Hermann today publishes on karate-jutsu's and karatedo's socio-cultural roles and their development. With YMAA Publication Center, he authored *Analysis of Genuine Karate—Misconceptions, Origin, Development, and True Purpose* in 2021 and, in 2023, *Analysis of Genuine Karate Volume 2—Sociocultural Development, Commercialization, and Loss of Essential Knowledge*, in addition to numerous articles. These publications shed light on the political reasons and arguments Japan used to redefine the Okinawan self-protection system (karate-jutsu) into a fine art and a path toward self-perfection (karatedo), and later into recreational sports-karate, with the related loss of essential knowledge through this socio-cultural development, and by Americanization, industrialization, and commercialization of the art.

Hermann started to train and to study karate—including its historical and socio-cultural development—in 1981. His experience covers old-style (non-sports) Japanese *Shudokan-Doshinkan* karatedo as well as classic Okinawan *Shorin Ryu* karate-jutsu. In addition, Hermann studies *Suikendo*, meaning “the art of fists flowing like water,” one of today’s most advanced karate fighting systems. Over the years he has spent considerable time with renowned Japanese, Western, and Okinawan teachers, all the while researching the socio-cultural backgrounds and the core essence of the styles they represent. Hermann holds black belt ranks in all those empty-hand and kobudo systems he studies.

Today, in his upper seventies, Hermann is still training hard; he practices karate daily and attends several weekly empty hand and kobudo trainings, completed by annual training camps in the USA and in Okinawa. To make a point about combining (not to be confused with “integrating”) traditional karate-jutsu and today’s sports karate, he continues to successfully compete in martial arts tournaments.

A centuries-old Japanese fine-arts principle finds its way into modern karate.

"Outstanding analysis of *Shu Ha Ri*, the developmental principle in Japanese karatedo that contrasts the philosophical basis of Okinawan karate."

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Hermann Bayer, Ph.D., examines why and how *Shu Ha Ri*, a centuries-old Japanese fine-arts concept, has changed how modern karate is practiced.

Shu Ha Ri is a genuine Japanese fine-arts principle that was later applied to Japanese martial arts in general and to karatedo in particular—not as a factual martial-arts tradition but as an *invented* one—during a process that also converted Okinawa's self-protection art into something closer to a fine art of self-perfection.

Clarifying the influence of *Shu Ha Ri* in the Japanese approach to martial arts is particularly important since traditional Okinawan karate circles insist on keeping their Okinawan karate approach unique and separate from Japanese ways.

Contents include:

- A centuries-old Japanese fine-arts principle finds its way into modern karate.
- *Shu Ha Ri* is a Japanese cultural concept, not an Okinawan one.
- Japan converts Okinawan karate-jutsu and inserts Japanese philosophies.
- The essence of *Shu Ha Ri* is its trinity of coexisting phases.

Dr. Bayer's analysis addresses doubts and questions about provenance and authenticity that are inevitable as an Okinawan fighting art is changed into a Japanese fine art.



Hermann Bayer, Ph.D., holds degrees in economics, sociology, and psychology. Hermann's karate training began in 1981. He has spent considerable time with renowned Japanese, Western, and Okinawan karate teachers, all the while researching the core essence of the style they represent. Hermann Bayer resides in Virginia Beach, Virginia.

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